

BANDEEP SINGH

CHHANNULAL MISHRA | b. 1936 |

Classical vocalist

Pandit Chhannulal Mishra's voice resonated with earthiness and sheer joy—the way one imagines Hindustani classical has every right to. At ease with dhrupad and khayal, the Kirana style overlaid on his native Benarasi, he had an infectious, child-like enthusiasm for the Gangetic species of song, the Dadra, the Thumri, the Chaiti, Kajri, Sawani and Holi. That spilled over in concerts, where he would converse with the audience, explaining the meaning, style and context of his music.



SWRAJ PAUL | b. 1931 |

NRI business baron

Indian-born British steel magnate Lord Swraj Paul, who died in London in August at 94, was widely known for his philanthropy in India, the US and Britain. A Labour peer from 1996, he left the party in 2010 to sit as a crossbencher. He was appointed deputy speaker of the House of Lords in 2008 and joined the Privy Council in 2009. The Caparo Group, which he founded in 1968, grew into one of the UK's largest steel conversion and distribution businesses.

RATAN THIYAM | b. 1948 |

Playwright & theatre director

Such was the impact of the Manipuri theatre auteur Ratan Thiyam that Indian theatre is almost unimaginable without the worlds he brought to the stage. A leading figure of the post-Independence 'Theatre of Roots' movement, he redefined decolonised performance through his Chorus Repertory Theatre. Blending the sculptural grace of Manipuri dance, the percussive ferocity of pung cholom, the ritualised combat of thang-ta, elemental song and disciplined drama, Thiyam forged visual spectacles that transcended language. His *Mahabharata* trilogy remains a gold standard, while his interpretation of Kalidasa's *Ritusamhara* was akin to witnessing magic on stage.



K ASIF



HEMANT PITHWA

SIMONE TATA | b. 1930 |

Former chairperson, Lakme; founder, Trent

Simone Tata, who died in December at 95, played a decisive role in shaping modern Indian consumer culture. Born in Geneva, she steered Lakme—set up by the Tata Group in 1952—into a national cosmetics brand, becoming its chairperson in the early 1980s, before founding the group's retail arm, Trent. Her association with India began with a tourist visit in 1953, when she met Naval Tata, Ratan Tata's father, who was divorced by then. They married in 1955, after which Mumbai became her home. Her son, Noel Tata, now chairs Tata Trusts and Trent.